

AETHER WIRELESS · KNOWLEDGE BASE

Device Trade-In Process

Category B — Policy & Process Knowledge Base

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Overview

This document outlines the end-to-end device trade-in process for Aether Wireless retail associates and customer care representatives. It covers eligibility requirements, device valuation methodology, step-by-step trade-in procedures, promotional stacking rules, and final device disposition. All trade-ins must follow these guidelines to ensure accurate valuation, compliance with data security standards, and consistent customer experience across all channels.

Eligibility Requirements

A device must meet all of the following criteria to qualify for trade-in through Aether Wireless:

- Ownership:** The device must be owned outright by the account holder. Devices financed through Aether Wireless must have the remaining balance paid in full before trade-in processing.
- Functional Status:** The device must power on and hold a charge. A device that does not power on or cannot hold battery charge is eligible only under the Non-functional (Tier F) classification.
- Account Status:** The customer must have an Active account in good standing. Accounts with suspended service, outstanding balances, or fraud flags are not eligible for trade-in.
- Lost/Stolen Status:** The device must not be reported as lost or stolen. Staff must verify the IMEI or serial number against the national lost/stolen database before proceeding.

Device Valuation

Valuation Factors

The following factors determine the final trade-in value. Values are applied as percentage adjustments to the base market price for the device model.

Factor	Adjustment	Notes
Age Depreciation	-12% to -15% per year	Calculated from original purchase date; pro-rated based on full years of ownership

Factor	Adjustment	Notes
Screen Cracks	-30% to -50%	Severity-based; hairline cracks at -30%, visible cracks affecting readability at -50%
Battery Health <80%	-10% to -20%	Devices showing maximum battery capacity below 80% of original rating
Activation Lock Present	Reject	Device must have Find My/iCloud/Google FRP disabled before trade-in
Water Damage	-40% to -60%	Liquid damage indicator triggered; severity-based
Frame Damage	-15% to -30%	Dents, scratches, or bends on the device frame; cosmetic vs. structural
Original Accessories Included	+\$10 to +\$20	Chargers, cables, original box, and unused headphones qualify
Jailbroken/iOSsid/Rooted	-20%	Device modified to bypass manufacturer security; reduces resale value

Valuation Tiers

Devices are classified into valuation tiers based on overall condition:

Tier	Classification	Criteria
A	Like New	No visible wear, screen and body pristine, battery >90%, fully functional
B	Good	Minor cosmetic scratches, battery >80%, fully functional
C	Fair	Visible wear, minor dents, screen scratches but readable, battery >70%
D	Poor	Significant damage, screen cracks, battery <70%, functional
E	Broken	Non-displaying screen, missing buttons, damaged ports, but powers on
F	Non-functional	Does not power on, liquid damage severe, missing major components

Trade-In Process

The trade-in flow consists of six stages:

- Device Diagnostics:** Associate or customer performs device diagnostics using the Aether Wireless Trade-In App. The app tests screen responsiveness, battery health, camera functionality, connectivity, and checks for activation lock status.
- Instant Quote Generation:** Based on diagnostic results and valuation factors, the system generates an instant quote valid for 14 calendar days. The quote displays the tier classification, itemized adjustments, and final credit amount.

3. **Credit at Point of Sale:** If the customer accepts the quote, the trade-in credit is applied immediately to the customer's account. Credits may be applied as account balance, bill credit, or toward the purchase of a new device. The customer receives a confirmation email with the quote reference number.
4. **Device Collection:** The customer has 7 calendar days to deliver the device to an Aether Wireless retail location or ship using the prepaid label provided. Devices received after the 7-day window require re-evaluation at current market rates.
5. **Refurbishment Inspection:** Upon receipt, the Device Finance team inspects the device against the original diagnostic report. If the condition matches the quote, the credit is finalized. If the device condition differs significantly (e.g., additional damage not reported), the quote is revised and the customer is notified of any credit adjustment or billing difference.
6. **Finalization or Billing:** For devices matching the quote, the trade-in is finalized and the customer receives a receipt. For devices with revised conditions, the customer is billed the difference if the new valuation is lower, or issued additional credit if higher.

Promotional Offers

Stacking Rules

Customers may combine trade-in value with promotional offers according to the following rules:

Promotion Type	Stackable with Trade-In?	Stackable with PROMO-0003 \$200 Bonus?	Stackable with Plan Promo?	Stackable with Another Device Promo?
Trade-In Value	—	Yes	Yes	No
PROMO-0003 (\$200 Bonus)	Yes	—	Yes	No
Plan Promo	Yes	Yes	—	No
Cash Discount	Yes	Yes	Yes	No

Note: Only one device promotion may be applied per transaction. Trade-in value may be combined with either PROMO-0003 or a plan promo, but not both device promos simultaneously.

Device Disposition

After inspection and finalization, devices are routed based on their valuation tier:

Tier	Classification	Disposition
A	Like New	Refurbished and resold as certified pre-owned
B	Good	Refurbished and resold as certified pre-owned
C	Fair	Refurbished and resold or sold to wholesale partner
D	Poor	Refurbished for parts or recycled through e-waste program
E	Broken	Recycled through certified e-waste processor

Tier	Classification	Disposition
F	Non-functional	Recycled through certified e-waste processor

All devices undergo data wipe procedures compliant with NIST Special Publication 800-88 prior to any disposition. Hard drives and storage media are securely erased or physically destroyed.

Quote Validity

All trade-in quotes are valid for **14 calendar days** from the time of generation. If the device is not received within this period, the quote expires and the device must be re-evaluated at current market rates. Customers may request a new quote at any time, though values may vary based on market conditions.

FAQs

Q: Can I trade in a device that is still under a payment plan?

A: No. Devices financed through Aether Wireless must have the remaining balance paid in full before they are eligible for trade-in. You may pay off the device balance at any retail location or through your online account, then proceed with trade-in.

Q: What happens if the device condition differs from my initial quote?

A: If our inspection finds condition discrepancies—such as additional screen cracks, water damage, or missing accessories—we will revise the valuation and notify you. If the new value is lower, the difference will be billed to your account. If the new value is higher, additional credit will be applied.

Q: How do I remove an activation lock before trading in?

A: For iOS devices, go to Settings > [Your Name] > Find My and disable Find My iPhone. For Android devices, go to Settings > Google > Security and remove the device from Find My Device. You must also disable Factory Reset Protection (FRP) by removing the Google account from the device before performing a factory reset.

Q: Can I trade in a device that belongs to someone else?

A: No. The trade-in must be completed by the account holder whose name is on the Aether Wireless account. You may not trade in a device owned by another person without written authorization and proof of ownership transfer.

Q: What happens to my personal data after I trade in the device?

A: All trade-in devices undergo data erasure compliant with NIST 800-88 standards before any disposition. We recommend performing a factory reset and removing your Google or Apple account from the device before handing it over. Aether Wireless is not responsible for any data remaining on devices after trade-in.

Q: How long does the entire trade-in process take?

A: The in-store process takes approximately 15–30 minutes for diagnostics and quote generation. Once you deliver or ship the device, finalization typically occurs within 3–5 business days after inspection. If all conditions match the quote, the credit is applied immediately upon finalization.

For additional assistance with trade-in eligibility, valuation disputes, or promotional stacking questions, contact Device Finance at 1-800-AETHER-4 (1-800-234-8374) or visit your nearest Aether Wireless retail location.